AI for politics

Democratic and authoritarian uses of artificial intelligence (AI)

POLI 158: AI & Politics · Session 17

Yiqing Xu

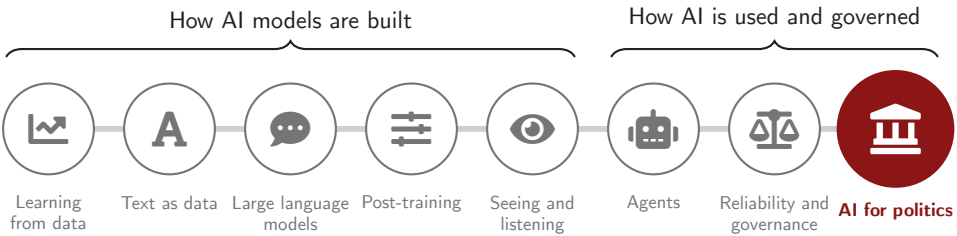
TODAY'S QUESTION

Does AI help democracies or dictators more?

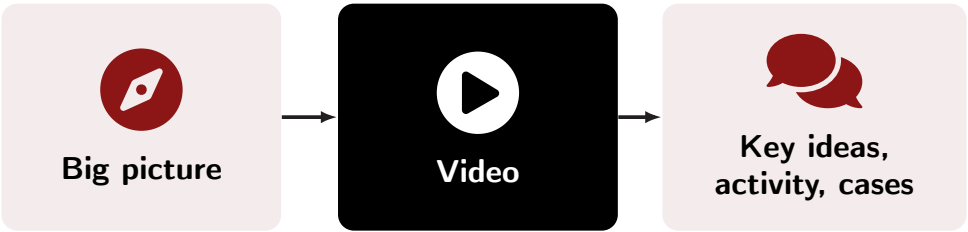


Vote now with a show of hands. We vote again at the end.

The eight Wednesday sessions



Today in three parts

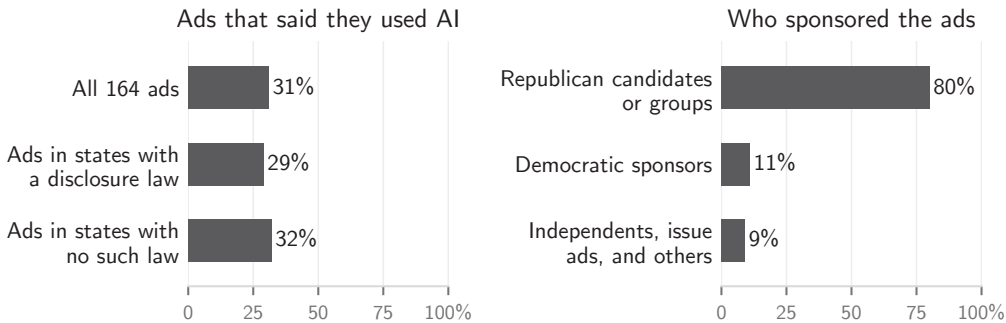


The AI you saw this campaign

 **Made with AI by whom?**  **Labeled or not?**  **Did it matter?**

Tell your neighbor about one AI-made item you saw this campaign.

AI ads counted before Election Day



At least 164 ads made or enhanced with AI. 69% had no AI disclosure.

Source: Wesleyan Media Project counts for the 2026 cycle, as of Sep 4, 2026 (release of that date; also reported by the Associated Press, Sep 25).

A map of AI in politics

	Democracies	Autocracies
Policymakers and officials	Detroit: a false face match (2020)	China: rules on what chatbots say (2023)
Campaigns and propagandists	Ireland: a fake withdrawal video (2025)	**Venezuela: AI news anchors (2023)**
Citizens and civil society	UK: an AI mediator for groups (2024)	**Venezuela: journalists' AI avatars (2024)**

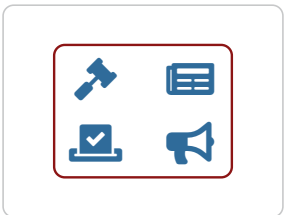
Red: a pair we come back to after the activity. Each case is sourced on a later page or on the Sources pages.

Three concepts in today's video



What AI makes cheaper

persuading, watching, administering



Checks on power

courts, a free press, elections, an opposition



The authoritarian data problem

self-censorship hides what people think

Video part 1: concepts 1 and 2. Part 2: concept 3.



AI and political power, part 1

Video

Key ideas: what AI makes cheaper

What AI makes cheaper

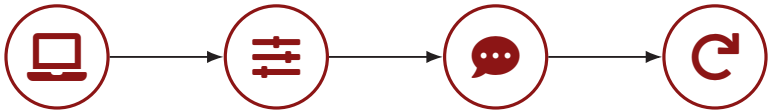
- **Persuading:** advocacy emails to 7,132 state legislators, by AI or by people. Reply rates were 2 points apart (United States, 2020).
- **Watching:** a face match sent Detroit police to arrest Robert Williams for a theft he did not commit (United States, 2020).
- **Administering:** about 500 public consultations a year, some with over 100,000 responses; an AI tool, in trial, sorts the answers by theme (United Kingdom, 2025).

Source: Kreps and Kriner (2024), *New Media & Society*; American Civil Liberties Union, *Williams v. City of Detroit*; Incubator for AI (2025), evaluation of its Consult tool; GOV.UK (May 14, 2025).

Activity: can a chatbot change your mind?

Activity: can a chatbot change your mind?

Activity laptops, on your own



Open the AI Playground; log in with your SUNet ID

Pick a policy (next page). Rate your support, 0 to 100

Ask for the strongest one-paragraph case for the side you oppose

Rate again. Compare with your neighbor

`https://aiplayground.stanford.edu`

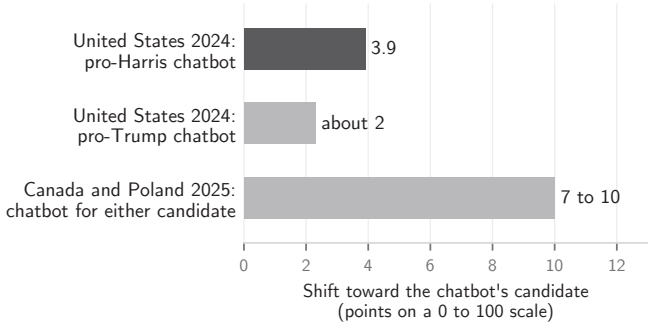
Policies to try

1. Require chatbots to say they are an AI in every conversation.
2. Ban phones in high school classrooms.
3. Allow driverless taxis, with no safety driver, in every U.S. city.
4. Require social media sites to check users' ages.

How far did you move?

- Show of hands: moved more than 10 points? Any change at all?
- Did you move toward the side you oppose, or away from it?
- What in the paragraph worked, or backfired?

Persuasion experiments with chatbots



Each bar shows the shift after one chat with a chatbot arguing for a candidate, among voters who leaned the other way. United States: chats about policy.

Lin et al. (2025), *Nature*: the paper's source data (Figures 1 and 4) and Cornell University's release (Dec 4, 2025); Hackenburg et al. (2025), *Science*; Costello, Pennycook and Rand (2024), *Science* (editorial expression of concern, June 2026).



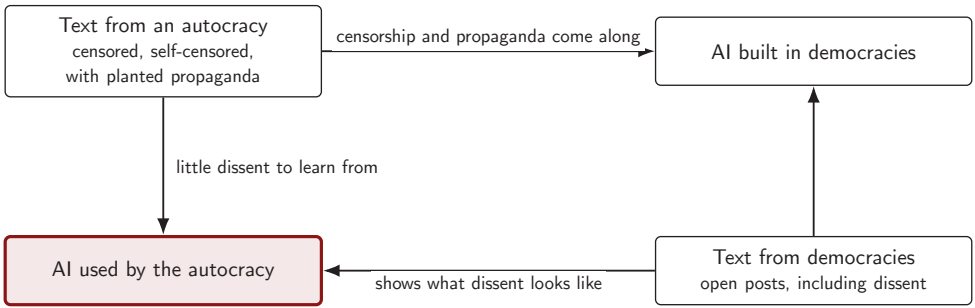
AI and political power, part 2

Video

Key ideas: the authoritarian data problem

The authoritarian data problem

Example: in counts published in 2023, Baidu Baike, a censored Chinese encyclopedia run by the company Baidu, had over 27 million entries. Chinese Wikipedia, blocked in China since 2015, had almost 1.4 million.



Source: Yang and Roberts (2023), *Journal of Democracy*; Yang (2024), "Authoritarianism could poison AI," blog post, Aug 8; Yang and Roberts (2021).

Cases

AI news presenters in Venezuela

- **Venezuelan state TV, 2023:** AI anchors "Noah" and "Daren," on a made-up channel, House of News, say reports of Venezuela's poverty are exaggerated. Made with a commercial avatar service (Synthesia).
- **Independent journalists, 2024:** after the July 28 election, at least seven journalists were detained. AI avatars "La Chama" and "El Pana" now read verified news from a dozen independent outlets.

Source: Semafor (Feb 21, 2023); LatAm Journalism Review (Feb 2023, citing *El País*; Aug 26, 2024, citing the Press and Society Institute of Venezuela).

Face recognition in Detroit and Moscow



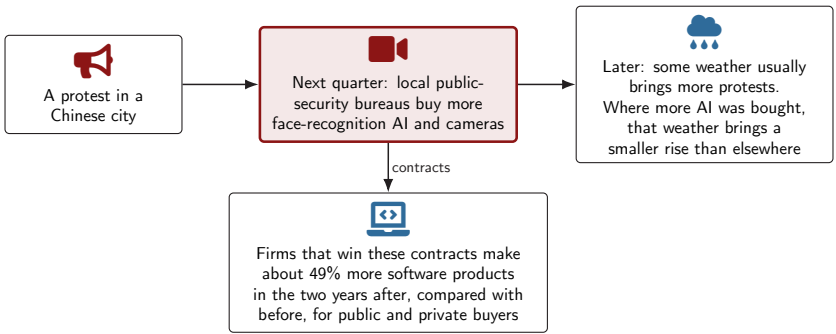
Source: American Civil Liberties Union, *Williams v. City of Detroit* (settlement of Jun 28, 2024); *Glukhin v. Russia*, European Court of Human Rights (Jul 4, 2023).

AI fakes in two elections

- **Ireland, October 2025:** a fake news bulletin showed candidate Catherine Connolly quitting the race. About 30,000 views before Meta removed it. She won the October 24 vote with 63% of first-preference votes.
- **Hungary, April 2026:** the governing party, Fidesz, ran AI videos, including a fake call between Ursula von der Leyen and Péter Magyar. An opposition party made AI clips too. Magyar's party, Tisza, won 141 of 199 seats.
- **2024 U.S. election:** the Alan Turing Institute found "a lack of evidence" that AI-made disinformation measurably changed the result, mainly for want of data.

Source: *Irish Times* (Oct 22, 2025); BreakingNews.ie (Oct 25, 2025); EU Perspectives (Apr 10, 2026); Daily News Hungary (Apr 18, 2026, final count); CETaS (Alan Turing Institute) report, Nov 2024.

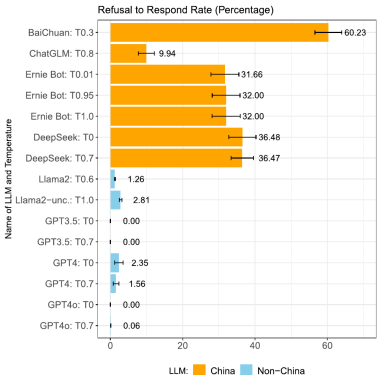
Protests and face recognition in China



- Data: about 3 million contracts (2013 to 2019) and 9,267 incidents of unrest (2014 to 2020).

Source: Beraja, Kao, Yang and Yuchtman (2023), *Quarterly Journal of Economics*; figures as summarized by the Massachusetts Institute of Technology's news office (Jul 13, 2023).

Chatbots made in China refuse political questions

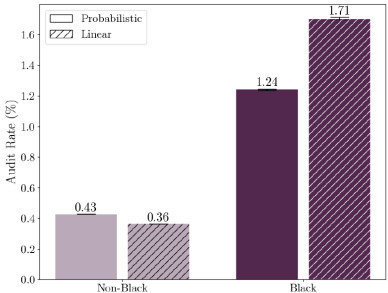


Share of 145 questions each model refused, asked in Chinese. Orange: made in China. From Figure 1.

- Two researchers asked nine chatbots 145 questions about Chinese politics, 100 times each, in 2023 and 2025.
- Four were made in China, where the government must approve a model before its release.
- The Chinese models refused 10% to 60% of the questions; the others refused under 3%.
- The gap shrank for less sensitive questions.

Source: Pan and Xu (2026), *PNAS Nexus* 5(2): pgag013, pp. 1–3 and 5; figure on p. 3.

An audit algorithm at the IRS



- The IRS picks many audits with an algorithm that never sees race.
- Black taxpayers were audited at 2.9 to 4.7 times the rate of others.
- A main cause: the algorithm looked for overclaimed tax credits rather than unpaid tax overall.
- In 2023 the IRS acknowledged the gap to Congress; audits of these credits fell 53% the next year.

Audit rates (%), tax year 2014, by two ways of estimating the rates. From Figure 3.

Source: Elzayn et al. (2025), *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 140(1): 113–163, abstract and pp. 4 and 23; figure on p. 26 of the authors' manuscript. IRS (2023), letter to Sen. Wyden; TIGTA (2025).

Back to today's question



1. Does AI help democracies or dictators more? Vote again.
2. Did anyone change their vote? Which case moved you?
3. Which check on power (courts, a free press, elections, an opposition) matters most for AI?

Where to go next at Stanford



CS 221
Artificial Intelligence: Principles and Techniques



CS 229
Machine Learning



CS 230
Deep Learning



CS 224N
Natural Language Processing with Deep Learning



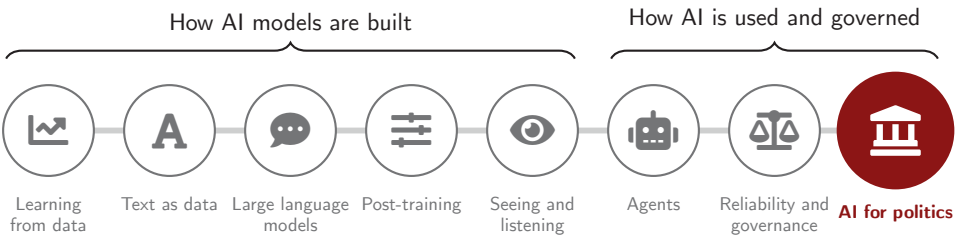
CS 234
Reinforcement Learning



STATS 315A
Modern Applied Statistics: Learning

Stanford Bulletin, 2026–27, and course websites (checked September 27, 2026). CS: Computer Science; STATS: Statistics.

Final presentations



Monday, November 30 and Wednesday, December 2

Backup slides

Backup activity: dual use

Activity: dual use

Activity devices closed, handout on paper



Dual use means that the same tool can help citizens or help an autocrat control them.
A safeguard can be technical (built into the tool) or institutional (a rule outside it).

Three tools to design



A. Ballot helper

A chatbot that explains the measures on a ballot in plain language.



B. Comment reader

A tool that summarizes public comments for a city council.



C. Deliberation assistant

A tool that drafts statements a divided group might agree on.

front of the room

Left side of the room: **A**

Middle: **B**

Right side: **C**

Tally of the swaps



- An autocracy could use the tool without changing its code or data: _____ of _____ groups.
- Safeguards: technical _____ institutional _____
- Which safeguard would still work if the people in power controlled the courts?

Evidence from today and the readings



Further reading: Harari (2018), "Why Technology Favors Tyranny"; Feldstein (2019).

Two AI videos from fall 2025

Posted October 17, 2025

National Republican Senatorial Committee

An AI Chuck Schumer speaks words from a print interview, published as text only.

Label: small, see-through "AI GENERATED" text.

Posted October 22, 2025

Andrew Cuomo's campaign for mayor of New York (independent)

An AI video of criminals endorsing his opponent, Zohran Mamdani.

No AI disclosure, a watchdog group said. Deleted about five minutes later, the campaign said.

Source: NPR (Oct 17, 2025); amNewYork (Oct 23, 2025).

AI stand-ins for politicians



Albania, 2025

Diella, an AI "minister"

September 2025: the prime minister names an AI avatar a minister, to keep public tenders free of corruption.

August 2026: the AI tender system is still at the planning stage.



Belarus's opposition, 2024

Yas Gaspadar, an AI "candidate"

A chatbot the opposition backed before the parliamentary election of February 25, 2024. Built to discuss topics no registered candidate would.

Source: TIME (Oct 10, 2025); Balkan Investigative Reporting Network (Aug 14, 2026); Semafor (Feb 23, 2024).

AI that reads what many people write

United Kingdom, 2025

Consult: sorting public comments

In a Scottish Government consultation, the AI tagged each answer with themes.

Officials checked every answer. They kept the AI's themes unchanged for 60% of them.

China, 2025

Reading minority languages

Systems in development, some in testing, to monitor and control what people say in Uyghur, Tibetan, Mongolian, and Korean.

Source: Incubator for AI (Mar 20, 2025), Consult evaluation; Australian Strategic Policy Institute (Dec 2025), "The party's AI", as reported by *The Register* (Dec 3, 2025).

Chatbots that answer political questions

Netherlands, October 2025

A regulator tests voting advice

Four chatbots, 3,000 made-up voter profiles.

Top pick in more than half of cases: Party for Freedom or GreenLeft-Labour.

It told voters not to use chatbots for voting advice.

China, 2023 rules

Values set by law

Generative AI services must "uphold the core socialist values" (Article 4).

2025 tests: Chinese models censored politically sensitive images more than American models.

Source: Al Jazeera (Oct 21, 2025); Dutch Data Protection Authority (Oct 2025), "AI chatbots as voting aid"; Interim Measures for the Management of Generative AI Services (2023), China Law Translate; Australian Strategic Policy Institute (2025), via *The Register*.

Sources: research

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